Predicting Indoor CO_2 Concentration from Sensor History and Building Occupancy

MMA3001 — Numerical Methods and Machine Learning, Project Report Dataset: MMA3001 Dataset 2 — Monash Smart Infrastructure Occupancy and Environmental Data **Repository:** https://github.com/tgup0010-bot/MMA3001_FINAL

---

1. Engineering Problem

1.1 Engineering Context

Ventilation is a building-services task within mechanical engineering: the heating, ventilation and air-conditioning (HVAC) system sets the rate at which outdoor air dilutes the carbon dioxide (CO_2) that occupants exhale. In a well-mixed room the concentration follows the single-zone mass balance (Persily & de Jonge, 2017):

$$\frac{dC}{dt} = \frac{G \cdot N}{V} - \lambda(C - C_{\text{out}})$$

where C is indoor CO_2 (ppm), G the per-person generation rate (about 0.2–0.3 L/min), N the number of occupants, V the room volume, λ the ventilation rate (air changes per hour) and C_{out} the outdoor concentration (about 420 ppm). CO_2 is therefore the control variable for demand-controlled ventilation (DCV), which sets outdoor airflow from measured CO_2 (Emmerich & Persily, 2001; ASHRAE, 2022a). HVAC uses roughly half of a building's energy (Pérez-Lombard et al., 2008), and sustained CO_2 above about 1000 ppm indicates inadequate ventilation (ASHRAE, 2022b).

1.2 The Problem Being Addressed

DCV reacts to the current reading: by the time CO_2 crosses its setpoint the air is already stale, and extra ventilation takes about one time constant $1/\lambda$ to act, about 15 minutes here (Section 4.2). A short-term forecast lets the system act earlier. But a forecast, and any control built on it, is only as good as the sensors, and the dataset is undocumented in key respects. The dataset brief asks both for "evaluating whether the available measurements support decisions about comfort or energy use" and for auditing "potentially unreliable observations". The project therefore addresses four questions:

- **RQ0. Can the sensor data be trusted?** Which readings are genuine, does the sensor measure real conditions (checked against independent Bureau of Meteorology weather), and what do the sensors need for maintenance?
- **RQ1.** Can CO_2 15 minutes ahead be forecast from recent sensor history and time of day, and which of the four Week 5 regression methods does it best?
- **RQ2.** Does building occupancy data improve that forecast?
- **RQ3.** Does adding a second sensor's data help, and does a model trained in one room transfer to another?

Criterion for a useful forecast: on a held-out later period, a model must beat the persistence forecast (next value equals current value), and its mean absolute error must be well below the 50 ppm margin used for an early-warning trigger (Section 2.5).

1.3 Intended Use

The forecaster is an advisory input to a building management system (BMS) or a facilities engineer. Every 15 minutes it takes the last hour of one room's CO_2 readings, the zone occupancy and the time, and returns the predicted CO_2 for the next 15 minutes; the BMS decides whether to raise outdoor airflow, and its own reactive setpoint stays in place as the safeguard, so the forecast is not safety-critical. The data audit (RQ0) serves the facilities team directly: which sensors to repair and what must be recorded before predictive control is worth installing.

1.4 Scope and Its Justification

Scope decision	Justification
Main analysis on sensor `6012002000326`; `6012002000869` added for RQ3	0326 has the longest record of genuine readings; three of the five sensors contain none (Appendix C)
One forecast horizon, 15 minutes	About one room time constant (Section 4.2), long enough to act on; and the grid of the occupancy data
The four Week 5 regression methods; no ARIMA or recurrent networks	The unit's methods, compared on equal terms; the lag and rolling features already give them the autoregressive structure of the mass balance
No ventilation-rate or outdoor CO_2 inputs	Not in the dataset, so λ and C_{out} cannot be modelled directly; the mass balance motivates the features instead
One building; no closed-loop control simulation	The dataset covers one site, and simulating fan control needs an HVAC model that is not available; the project evaluates forecast quality only

2. Inputs and Outputs

2.1 Top-Level Inputs

Input file	Format	Content used	Sampling and period
Environmental sensor log (`5EnvSensor_…csv`, 337 MB)	CSV; a `jsondata` column holds a JSON array of variables, each with a Unix-epoch `time` and `value`	CO_2 (ppm), temperature (°C), relative humidity (%) for 5 sensors; `createdate` (server receive time)	Every 10 min when working; genuine readings Feb–Jun 2024 (0869) and Sep 2025–Apr 2026 (0326)
Occupancy event log (`5occupancySensor_…csv`, 1.5 GB)	CSV; one row per change of state	`floorspaceid` (zone); `occupancystatus`: CurrentlyOccupied, RecentlyOccupied or NotOccupied; `collecteddate`	Irregular (event-driven); 5 zones, Nov 2023–Apr 2026
Sensor ID and Locations (`.xlsx`)	Lookup table	Room of each device	Sensor 0326 is not listed
Bureau of Meteorology daily observations, Moorabbin Airport, station 086077	Monthly CSV	9 am temperature and humidity	Daily, 222 days overlapping sensor 0326

The raw files exceed GitHub's 100 MB limit, so compact processed copies of the parts used are committed in `data/processed/`; every script uses the raw files when present and the copies otherwise, with identical results (README).

2.2 From Raw Data to Model Inputs

Time. All timestamps are converted to UTC and then to Australia/Melbourne local time, so the time-of-day features follow the building's clock across daylight-saving changes (the raw offsets switch between +10 and +11 hours).

Binning. The sensors report every 10 minutes; readings are averaged into 15-minute bins (one or two readings each), the grid of the occupancy data, and a bin with no reading is missing. Section 5.6 shows 10-minute bins give the same forecast skill.

Occupancy. A zone is occupied in a bin if its most recent status within the previous 2 hours is `CurrentlyOccupied`; `RecentlyOccupied`, the sensor's post-departure cooldown state, counts as not occupied. A zone with no event in the previous 2 hours is unknown. `building_occupancy` is the number of the five zones occupied: unknown zones count as not occupied, and the value is missing only when all five are unknown. The log's `headcount` column is not used, so the feature counts occupied zones, not people.

Formulation. The model learns $\hat{C}_{t+1} = f(C_t, C_{t-1}, \bar{C}_{t-1\text{h}}, O_t, \tau_t)$: next-bin CO_2 from the current and previous bins, the 1-hour mean, occupancy O_t and time context τ_t. Solving the mass balance over one step Δt with occupancy and ventilation held constant gives $C_{t+1} = e^{-\lambda\Delta t} C_t + (1 - e^{-\lambda\Delta t}) C_{ss}$, where $C_{ss} = C_{\text{out}} + GN/(\lambda V)$: the next value is a scaled copy of the current one plus a term set by occupancy and ventilation, which is why these are the inputs.

Feature	Units, type	Description
`co2_now`	ppm, continuous	CO_2 in the current bin; the strongest single predictor
`co2_lag1`	ppm, continuous	CO_2 15 minutes ago; with `co2_now`, a backward difference giving the current trend
`co2_rolling_1h`	ppm, continuous	Mean of the last four bins including the current one; the medium-term trend
`building_occupancy`	count, integer 0–5	Zones occupied (definition above); tested in RQ2 because N drives generation
`hour_sin`, `hour_cos`	−1 to 1	Hour of day as (sin $(2\pi h/24)$, cos $(2\pi h/24)$), so 23:45 sits next to 00:00
`dow_sin`, `dow_cos`	−1 to 1	Day of week, encoded the same way
`is_weekend`	0 or 1	1 on Saturday and Sunday

2.3 Input Domains

Two domains are distinguished. The **valid domain** is what the model accepts at all, checked by `occupancy.input_validation`: CO_2 inputs 350–5000 ppm (below outdoor air is impossible; 5000 ppm is the 8-hour occupational limit), occupancy a whole number 0–5, hour 0–23, day 0–6. The **trained domain** is the range of values in the training data: current CO_2 from 400 to 1387 ppm, but 99.5% of the 13,608 training rows lie between 400 and 550 ppm, so accuracy is established mainly in that band (Section 5.2). Valid inputs outside the training range are predicted but flagged as extrapolation.

2.4 Invalid, Missing and Unsupported Inputs

Missing. A row with any missing input or target is dropped, never filled. The dominant loss is a 636-day gap in genuine readings (11 December 2023 to 7 September 2025): imputing across it would invent hundreds of thousands of readings. Of 84,576 candidate 15-minute timestamps, 17,010 (20.1%) are complete and used. In effect only *unbroken intervals* are kept: runs of consecutive bins with no gap. A row needs four bins of history plus the next bin as target, so any interval of at least 75 minutes contributes, and an interval of n bins yields $n - 4$ rows; sensor 0326 has 649 such intervals covering 4,978 hours. (Section 5.3 has 307 more rows, as it does not need occupancy.)

Invalid. Three checks apply to the raw data. A reading received more than a day after its own timestamp is a re-sent stale packet, not a measurement; three sensors consist entirely of these (Appendix C). Failed reads (no value) and malformed JSON payloads are skipped when the log is loaded. For a forecast query, `validate_query` rejects values outside the valid domain with the reason, and the demonstration program refuses to predict from them.

Unsupported. Valid but outside what the model was built for: CO_2 outside the trained range (flagged), a different room (Section 5.3) or a different bin size or horizon (retrain). These are stated here and in the README.

2.5 Outputs

Output	Units	Meaning and intended use
Forecast CO_2 for the next 15 minutes	ppm	The main output: an advisory input to the BMS. Typical error 8.1 ppm (MAE, selected SVR); sudden rises are not anticipated (Section 5.2)
Extrapolation warning	text	Flags a forecast made outside the trained domain
Model metrics (JSON in `reports/`)	ppm, R^2	Compare methods and select the model (Section 5)
Test-set predictions (CSV in `reports/`)	ppm	Residual and diagnostic analysis (Section 5.2)
Cumulative CO_2 exposure (JSON in `reports/`)	ppm·h	Occupant exposure over a period; verifies the integration methods (Section 4.2)
Sensor audit results (JSON in `reports/`)	Pearson r	Whether a sensor measures real conditions and which zone it serves (Sections 4.2, 6)

The model only forecasts; thresholds and ventilation commands belong to the BMS. A practical rule might set an early-warning trigger at 750 ppm, 50 ppm below 800 ppm, a common stricter target than the 1000 ppm guideline. The 50 ppm margin is about six times the MAE and twice the RMSE of the selected model (Section 5). Each function's inputs and outputs are documented in its docstring and the HTML documentation.

---

3. Computational Approach

3.1 Methods and Why They Were Selected

The forecast is a supervised regression from the nine inputs of Section 2.2 to next-bin CO_2. The four Week 5 methods were compared because they span fully interpretable to highly flexible: **Linear Regression**, a **Decision Tree**, **SVR** and a **neural network**, against a **persistence** floor (next value equals current value). The Week 6 **trapezoidal and Simpson's rules** compute cumulative CO_2 exposure and serve as an independent numerical check on the data pipeline.

3.2 How Each Method Works on This Problem

Each learns, from the 13,608 training rows, a map from the nine inputs to CO_2 15 minutes later. **Linear Regression** fits $\hat{C}_{t+1} = \beta_0 + \sum_{i=1}^{9} \beta_i x_i$ by least squares: in effect current CO_2 plus a share of the recent trend plus fixed time-of-day offsets, the one-step mass-balance solution with constant coefficients. *Here:* instant (36 FLOPs) and readable, but additive only (it cannot make the trend count more on weekday mornings), and squaring errors lets the rare spikes pull the fit.

Decision Tree Regression splits the inputs by yes/no rules (such as CO_2 above a threshold, before 08:00, weekend) chosen to minimise target variance; each leaf predicts its rows' mean. *Here:* readable and non-linear, but its output is a staircase that cannot exceed training values, and untuned (depth 8, leaves of one row) it memorised the training period and predicted spikes that never happened (Section 5.2).

SVR finds the flattest function, in the space defined by the RBF kernel $K(\mathbf{x}_i, \mathbf{x}_j) = \exp(-\gamma \| \mathbf{x}_i - \mathbf{x}_j \|^2)$, that keeps residuals within a tube of half-width ε; C penalises points outside it in proportion to the miss, not its square. Training is convex (one global optimum); every row on or outside the tube becomes a *support vector*, and each prediction sums a kernel term over all of them. *Here:* a 2 ppm tube ignores the sensor's whole-ppm noise and the linear penalty stops rare spikes dominating the fit; the price is cost (10,437 support vectors) and opacity.

The neural network is a multilayer perceptron with ReLU hidden layers and a linear output, trained with Adam and early stopping. *Here:* the most flexible, but 13,608 rows of mostly flat CO_2 give it little to exploit, its loss is non-convex, and its test MAE varies by 0.6 ppm with the random seed (Section 5.6).

Numerical integration. Cumulative exposure $E = \int C\,dt$ (ppm·h) is computed with the trapezoidal rule on the actual, irregular reading times (error $O(h^2)$) and with composite Simpson's 1/3 rule on a regular grid (error $O(h^4)$, needs an even number of intervals). A gap-aware variant skips panels wider than 2 hours, so the rule never interpolates across a sensor outage.

3.3 Assumptions

1. The room is well mixed, so one sensor represents it (the mass balance of Section 1.1).
2. The last hour of CO_2 plus time of day carries the information needed to forecast 15 minutes ahead (autoregression).
3. The process is stationary over the record: the training period behaves like the test period. This is what the chronological split tests.
4. A 15-minute mean of the 10-minute readings is representative of the bin.
5. Bins with missing data are absent, not zero; gaps over 2 hours are unknown.

3.4 Settings

All four models are scikit-learn `Pipeline` objects: a `StandardScaler` (fitted on training rows only, so no test information leaks into the scaling) followed by the regressor. Scaling matters most for SVR and the neural network, whose distances and gradients would otherwise be dominated by CO_2 in hundreds of ppm beside a 0/1 weekend flag.

Setting	Original value	Selected value (Section 5.4)	Role
Tree `max_depth`, `min_samples_leaf`	8, 1	4, 50	Limit tree size; prevent memorising the training period
SVR C, ε, γ	10, 0.5 ppm, `scale` (≈0.11)	100, 2 ppm, 0.03	Penalty outside the tube, tube half-width, kernel width
MLP layers, α (L2 penalty)	32→16, 10^{-4}	64→32, 1.0	Capacity and weight regularisation
MLP training	Adam, early stopping (10% validation, patience 10), at most 500 iterations, seed 42	same	Convergence criterion and repeatability
Split	80/20 chronological, cutoff 11 March 2026	same	Training 13,608 rows, test 3,402

Original values were set by hand, selected values by tuning (Section 5.4). The original $\varepsilon = 0.5$ ppm is below the sensor's 1 ppm resolution, so 12,807 of 13,608 training rows became support vectors.

3.5 Implementation

The code is a Python package, `src/occupancy`, with one module per task; scripts in `scripts/` call it and write every reported number to `reports/*.json`, running from a fresh clone on the committed processed data. Seeds are fixed, 92 unit tests run on every push, and HTML documentation is generated from the docstrings.

3.6 Known Limitations of the Methods

Each model's limitations on this problem are given with it in Section 3.2: additive only (Linear Regression), a staircase that cannot extrapolate (tree), cost and opacity (SVR) and seed dependence (neural network). Simpson's rule needs equally spaced, gap-free data, and neither rule recovers unrecorded readings.

---

4. Validation

4.1 Verification: Is the Code Correct?

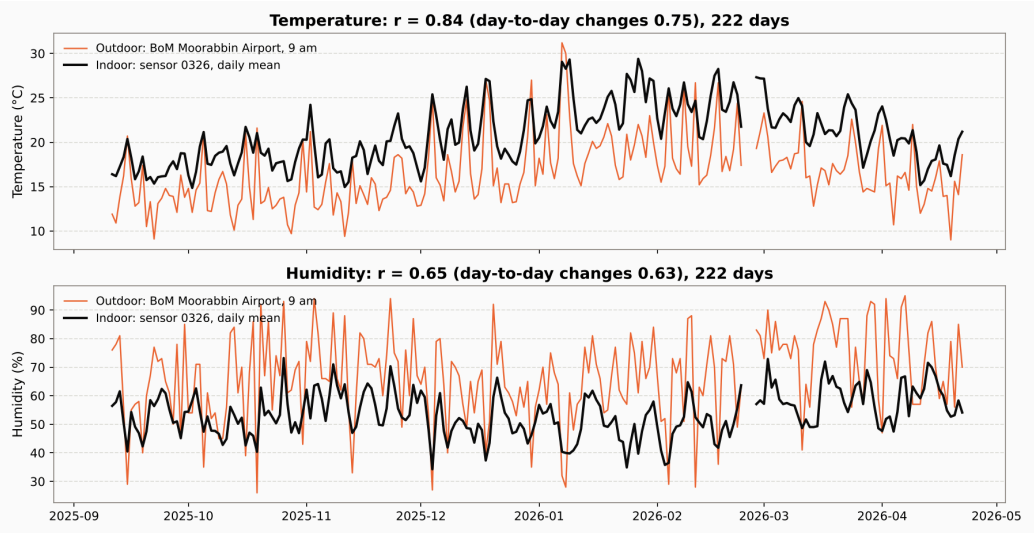
Numerical code was first checked against problems with known answers, in 92 automated tests (`tests/`, report in `reports/test_report.html`). The trapezoidal rule integrates a constant exactly and matches the unit's worked example; Simpson's rule is exact for a quadratic; a Richardson check confirms the expected error reduction (4× for trapezoidal, 16× for Simpson's when h halves); the metrics match hand-computed values, and predicting the mean gives $R^2 = 0$; the lagged-correlation search finds a planted CO_2 response and stays weak for unrelated series; the

decay-rate fit recovers a known ventilation rate from a manufactured exponential; and the processed data reads back identical to the raw files.

4.2 Validation Design

What was validated: the forecast accuracy of each model (RQ1–RQ3), the reliability of the sensor itself (RQ0), the physical plausibility of its readings, and the integration results.

Evidence (brief's category)	Method	Why appropriate
Withheld test data	Last 20% of rows in time order, used once at the end	Matches deployment: the model only ever sees the past. A random split would place test rows beside near-identical training rows 15 minutes away and measure interpolation, not forecasting
Cross-validation	5-fold time-series cross-validation inside the training period (each fold trains on earlier rows, scores on the next block)	Selects settings and the final model without touching the test data
Trusted benchmark	Persistence forecast; bootstrap intervals on paired error differences (one-day blocks, as errors are correlated in time)	A model that cannot beat "no change" is useless; the intervals show whether differences are larger than chance
Independent data (RQ0)	Sensor 0326's daily mean temperature and humidity vs Bureau of Meteorology 9 am observations, 222 days: r = +0.84 and +0.65; day-to-day changes +0.75 and +0.63 (figure below)	A faulty sensor would give r near zero; changes remove the shared seasonal trend. Air-conditioning damps the outdoor swing, so $r < 1$
Physical constraint	Decay of 87 sharp CO_2 releases fitted to the mass balance: ventilation rate 3.9 h^{-1} (interquartile range 2.9–5.1), time constant about 15 minutes	Exponential decay at a consistent rate across 87 events, as the mass balance predicts; a sensor artefact would not do this
Established method	Trapezoidal vs Simpson's on a 41-hour gap-free window: agree within 0.1% at 15, 30 and 60-minute spacing (Appendix B)	Two independent rules agreeing shows the data handling, not just one formula, is consistent



Sensor 0326 against independent Bureau of Meteorology weather, 7 September 2025 to 22 April 2026 (RQ0): the sensor measures real conditions

Metrics and acceptance criteria. MAE (typical error, ppm) is the selection metric; RMSE (sensitive to large misses) and R^2 (variance explained relative to predicting the mean) are reported alongside. Acceptance, from Section 1.2: beat persistence with a bootstrap interval excluding zero, and MAE well below the 50 ppm alarm margin.

Did validation influence model selection? Yes, but only the cross-validation scores did. The original comparison (Section 5.1) chose SVR by its test-set MAE, which lets the test data influence the choice; this was corrected in Section 5.4, where tuning and selection use the training period only and the test period is used once.

What validation cannot establish. Other rooms (models do not transfer, Section 5.3), other seasons or a changed HVAC schedule; whether ventilation control would actually improve (a closed-loop trial); and accuracy at high CO_2, with only 25 test rows above 550 ppm.

---

5. Comparison and Optimisation

5.1 Baseline Comparison (Original Settings)

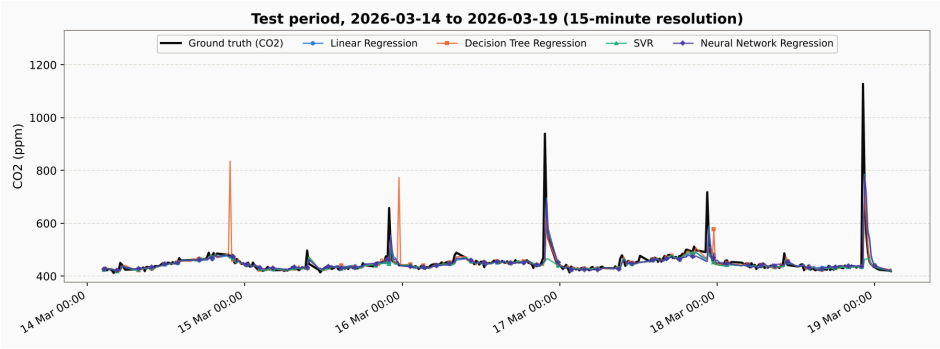
Method	MAE (ppm)	RMSE (ppm)	R^2	Training MAE (ppm)
Persistence (benchmark)	9.89	29.34	0.155	n/a
Linear Regression	9.01	**25.58**	**0.358**	7.67
Decision Tree	9.35	28.71	0.191	6.71
SVR	**8.35**	25.89	0.342	6.80
Neural Network	9.35	26.02	0.336	7.88

Test period: 3,402 rows. All four models beat persistence. SVR has the lowest MAE, and the bootstrap interval on its advantage over Linear Regression (0.66 ppm, 95% interval 0.39 to 0.94) excludes zero; Linear Regression has the lowest RMSE and highest R^2. The Decision Tree overfits: it has the lowest training error but the gap to its test error is the largest (6.71 vs 9.35 ppm).

RQ2, occupancy. Removing building occupancy changes R^2 by at most 0.002 for Linear Regression, SVR and the neural network, and improves the Decision Tree (0.191 to 0.331), which was spending splits on it. Section 6 explains why: nothing links this sensor to any monitored zone. Its daily cycle agrees: it peaks at 07:00 and has identical weekday and weekend working-hours means (436 ppm), following the ventilation schedule, whereas room G.38 (sensor 0869) peaks at 13:00 and is 55 ppm higher on weekdays.

5.2 Where the Models Fail

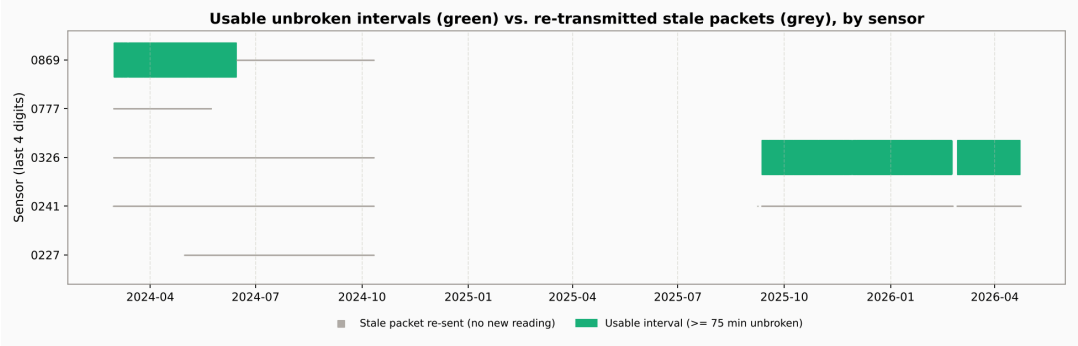
The averages hide the important failure. On the 63 test rows where CO_2 rose by more than 30 ppm within 15 minutes, **no model predicted any of the rise**: the median share of the rise predicted is zero, and their error there (about 110 ppm) equals the persistence error. The figure shows the signature: every model follows a spike one step late, missing the rise and then over-predicting the fall (the predicted-vs-actual and residual plots in Appendix A show the same). The original SVR never predicted above 512 ppm and is biased low by 2.9 ppm. The models therefore beat persistence by smoothing normal fluctuations, not by anticipating releases, which come from events the inputs cannot see.



Five days of the test period at 15-minute resolution, original settings: every model follows each spike one step late, and the original Decision Tree also predicts spikes that never happened (full test period in Appendix A)

5.3 More Data and Other Rooms (RQ3)

Cutting each sensor's record into unbroken intervals adds sensor 0869 (room G.38): 7,781 rows from February to June 2024; the other three sensors only ever re-send one stale packet (Appendix C). Using original settings and no occupancy: pooling both sensors (+56% training rows) changes SVR's MAE from 8.30 to 8.14 ppm, and no model's change is significant (all bootstrap intervals span zero). Trained on its own room, every model beats persistence on sensor 0869 (SVR MAE 6.99 ppm, R^2 0.78); trained on the other room, every model is worse than persistence (7.75 ppm; chart in Appendix A). A forecaster must be trained for each room.



Usable unbroken intervals (green) and re-sent stale packets (grey) for each sensor (RQ0): only sensors 0326 and 0869 contain genuine readings

5.4 Optimisation: Tuning and the Selected Design

Each method's settings were tuned by grid search (Section 3.4 lists the ranges) with 5-fold time-series cross-validation on the training period only, and the final model was chosen by cross-validated MAE (`scripts/optimisation_and_performance.py`).

Method	CV MAE, original (ppm)	CV MAE, tuned (ppm)	Test MAE, tuned (ppm)	Test R^2, tuned
Linear Regression	7.67	7.67 (no settings)	9.01	0.358
Decision Tree	8.84	7.88	8.93	0.371
SVR (selected)	7.49	**7.26**	**8.11**	0.372
Neural Network	8.53	8.37	8.86	0.376

SVR has the lowest cross-validated error, and in every one of the five folds (tuning curves in Appendix A). **Why SVR wins:** most 15-minute changes are a few ppm of sensor noise around a slowly moving level, broken by rare spikes no input foresees. SVR's 2 ppm tube ignores the noise and its linear penalty keeps the spikes from distorting the fit, so it has the lowest typical error (MAE); RMSE and R^2 are dominated by the unforeseeable spikes, so they barely separate the four models. On the test period the selected SVR (C = 100, ε = 2 ppm, γ = 0.03) improves on the original SVR by 0.24 ppm (95% interval 0.10 to 0.43) and beats every alternative: persistence by 1.78 ppm (1.32 to 2.30), Linear Regression by 0.91 ppm (0.68 to 1.16), the tuned tree by 0.82 ppm and the tuned neural network by 0.76 ppm (both intervals exclude zero). Tuning fixed the tree's overfitting (test R^2 0.191 to 0.371). The selected design meets the acceptance criteria: it beats persistence, and its 8.1 ppm MAE is a sixth of the 50 ppm margin.

5.5 Performance: Time, Memory and Operations

Model (selected settings)	Fit (s)	Predict 3,402 rows (ms)	FLOPs per prediction	Model size (kB)
Linear Regression	0.007	1.6	36	1
Decision Tree	0.017	1.3	22 (comparisons)	4
SVR	5.4	924	5.1×10^5	879
Neural Network	4.1	2.2	5.5×10^3	78

Times are medians of repeated runs; peak memory while fitting was 2–4 MB. An RBF-SVR prediction costs about $n_{sv}(3d + 22)$ FLOPs: with d = 9 inputs and 10,437 support vectors, about 500,000 per row, 14,000 times the linear

model's 36. At 0.6 FLOP per byte read, SVR prediction is memory-bound (1.9 GFLOP/s measured, against 8.4 for the neural network). Tuning cut the support vectors from 12,807 to 10,437 (about 20% faster); 0.3 ms per forecast is negligible for a decision every 15 minutes. Profiling (`cProfile`) from the raw files put 54% of the time in reading and parsing the 1.9 GB of CSV and 7% in fitting SVR; the processed data cuts the main experiment from 109 s to 26 s.

5.6 Sensitivity and Robustness

- **Input resolution.** SVR's skill over persistence is 18% for 10- and 15-minute bins and 15% for 30-minute bins: 15 minutes loses nothing.
- **Data requirement.** With only the latest quarter of the training rows, SVR's test MAE is 8.30 ppm (8.11 with all); Linear Regression needs the full set (9.91 to 9.01). More data of the same kind is not the bottleneck.
- **Repeatability.** SVR gives identical results on every run. The tuned neural network's test MAE ranges from 8.68 to 9.26 ppm over five random seeds, a spread larger than most differences between methods.
- **Robustness over time.** The cross-validation folds cover different months; fold MAE varies from 5.9 to 8.4 ppm for SVR, and SVR is best in every fold.
- **Integration gap threshold.** Exposure changes by 1.2% for thresholds from 0.5 to 24 hours (2.29 to 2.31 million ppm·h), but bridging the 636-day outage inflates it fourfold (9.54 million): only the outage matters.
- **Outliers.** A Hampel filter (5 robust standard deviations from the hourly median) flags 293 of 29,038 genuine readings (1.0%): rises with smooth decays, genuine releases, not glitches. Replacing them worsens the test MAE (8.11 to 8.22 ppm), so they were kept.

Final design. The tuned SVR is selected: it is the most accurate on every validation measure, and its cost is irrelevant at a 15-minute decision interval. Linear Regression remains the fallback where interpretability or a tiny model matters: 0.9 ppm less accurate, with 36 operations per forecast and coefficients an engineer can read.

---

6. Conclusions, Limitations and Lessons Learned

Conclusions. *RQ0:* only sensors 0326 and 0869 contain genuine readings; 0326 follows independent Bureau of Meteorology weather, and its CO_2 decays give a ventilation rate of 3.9 h^{-1}, a well-ventilated space. *RQ1:* the tuned SVR forecasts 15 minutes ahead with an MAE of 8.1 ppm, 18% better than persistence (significant), but only for gradual changes; it does not anticipate sudden rises. *RQ2:* occupancy does not help, because sensor 0326 is in none of the monitored zones. *RQ3:* pooling does not help and models do not transfer; each room needs its own model. **For the building:** repair or replace the three sensors that only re-send stale packets, record where every sensor is mounted, and place occupancy sensing in the same rooms as the CO_2 sensors before investing in predictive ventilation; until then the measurements support monitoring air quality, which is good (99% of the 29,038 genuine readings at or below 516 ppm), but not predictive control.

Limitations.

- **No model anticipates sudden rises** (Section 5.2). The forecast suits gradual, early ventilation changes, not a replacement for the BMS's reactive alarm.
- **The main sensor has no documented room.** Sensor 0326 is not in the location spreadsheet, and no zone's occupancy correlates with its 15-minute CO_2 *change*: $|r| \leq 0.03$ at lags up to ±1 hour (changes, because levels share the daily cycle; Appendix C). Temperature reaches $r = 0.27$ but rises 45–60 minutes *before* occupancy: the HVAC warm-up. This explains RQ2.
- **Three of five sensors contain no genuine readings**: they only re-send one stale packet (e.g. 666 ppm in all 21,363 rows of sensor 0227), found by comparing timestamps with server receive times; this is undocumented.
- **80% of candidate rows are dropped** because of the 636-day outage, and only 25 test rows exceed 550 ppm.
- **Accuracy is moderate** (R^2 about 0.37): two thirds of the variance comes from factors not in the data (doors, windows, HVAC switching, the room's own occupants).
- **One room, one building, seven months**; models must be retrained per room.

Lessons learned.

1. **Audit the raw data, and check it against independent data, before modelling.** The three "frozen" sensors, the outage and the missing room location were found by inspecting timestamps, not by the models;

the Bureau of Meteorology check showed the main sensor is real.

2. **Averages can hide the failure that matters.** A better MAE came from smoothing ordinary noise; the spikes an early warning exists for were not predicted at all.
3. **Never let the test set choose the model.** The first comparison did; time-series cross-validation inside the training period fixed it, and the selected model was confirmed only once on the test data.
4. **Check claims against the data.** Two stated justifications (the 15-minute sensor cadence and ε matched to sensor noise) were false when measured, and an assumed 30-minute time constant was really about 15 minutes.
5. **Numerical methods fail at the data, not the formula.** The trapezoidal rule was correct, but applied across an outage it inflated exposure fourfold.
6. **Report negative results.** Each of occupancy, pooling and transfer failing narrowed what a deployment needs (Conclusions above).

---

7. AI Use and Reflection

Tools. Claude Code (Anthropic), used in a cloud session with access to the repository, and the Claude chat interface (claude.ai), used to read the brief, plan and review.

What AI was used for, and approximate contribution. Claude wrote most of the Python code (an estimated 80–90% of lines), ran the analyses, generated the figures and API documentation, and drafted most of the report prose, including the revision of every section against the brief and rubric. My contribution was the engineering direction, the decisions listed below, checking results and editing. I used AI for implementation and drafting because it is fast at boilerplate code, plotting and restructuring text, which left my time for the engineering judgements.

Decisions that remained mine. Choosing CO_2 forecasting over occupancy classification; choosing the sensor and requiring the Bureau of Meteorology check before trusting it; testing occupancy as a feature rather than assuming its value; taking the teaching team's advice to use every sensor's valid intervals; deciding to report the non-significant pooling result and the negative transfer result as they are; and accepting the final model and its stated limitations.

How AI output was checked. Every number in this report was traced to an output file in `reports/` produced by a script that reruns from a fresh clone; I read the code paths behind key results; the numerical code is covered by unit tests with known answers (Section 4.1); and claims were rechecked against the raw data.

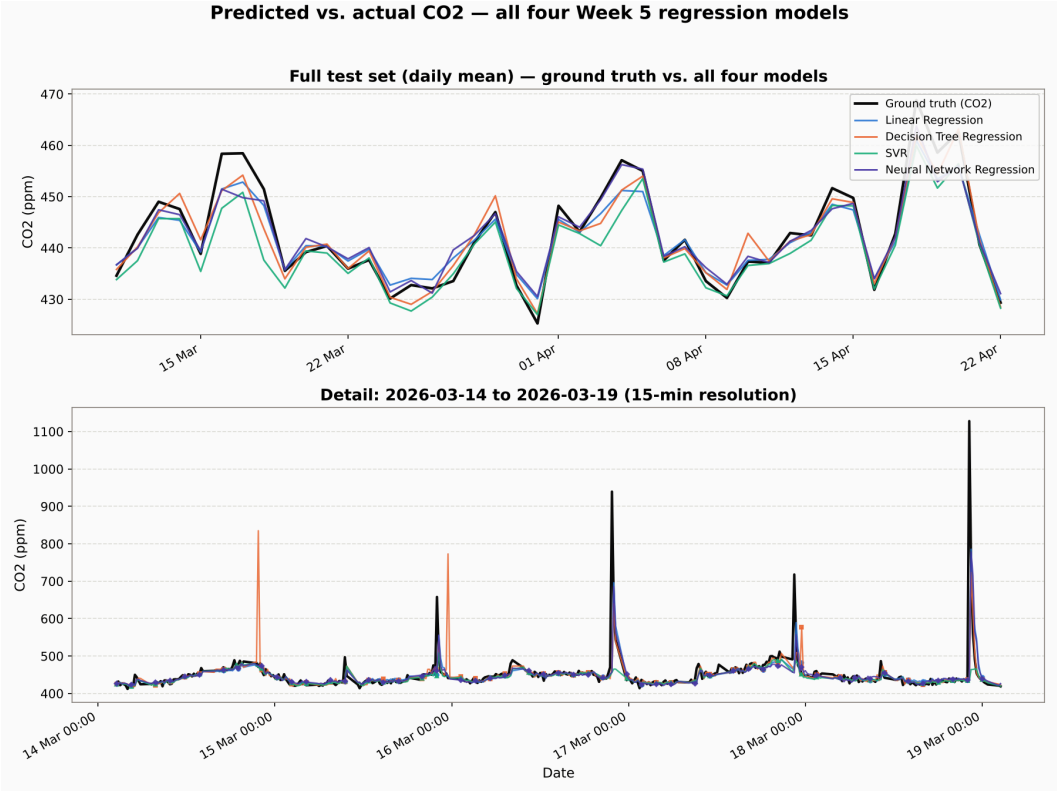
Errors and unhelpful output from AI. The first integration code bridged the 636-day outage and inflated exposure fourfold; I required an explanation when the result looked wrong, which exposed it. An AI clean-up deleted a module and its tests, later restored. AI-written text stated two justifications that measurement showed false (the 15-minute cadence and the ε setting), described the residual plot backwards, and misreported the integration discrepancy as ninefold. The original model comparison selected SVR on test data, a methodological flaw the AI did not flag until the work was audited. AI also added itself as a co-author on a commit against my instruction, and once said the processed data was committed when it was not. Each was found by checking output against the data, the code or the repository.

Effect on understanding and workflow: benefits and drawbacks. The benefit was scale: AI made it possible to run far more analysis than I could have coded alone (cross-validation, bootstrap intervals, profiling, the decay fit). The drawback was confident errors that looked plausible, so checking took real time; the errors above taught me to treat every AI statement as a claim to verify rather than a result.

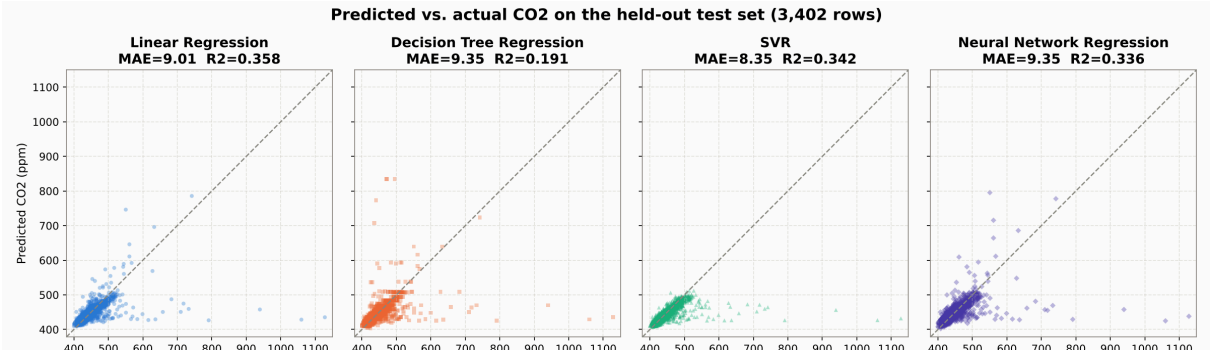
References

- MMA3001 Project Brief, Monash University, 2026.
- MMA3001 Project Datasets document, Monash University, 2026. Dataset 2: Monash Smart Infrastructure Occupancy and Environmental Data.
- MMA3001 Notes, Week 5.1–5.6: Regression methods and evaluation. Monash University, 2026.
- MMA3001 Notes, Week 6: Numerical Integration (trapezoidal, Simpson's, Richardson extrapolation). Monash University, 2026.
- ACGIH. Carbon dioxide: TLV-TWA 5000 ppm. American Conference of Governmental Industrial Hygienists; also OSHA Permissible Exposure Limit, 29 CFR 1910.1000 Table Z-1 (5000 ppm, 8-hour TWA).
- ASHRAE (2022a). Standard 62.1: Ventilation and Acceptable Indoor Air Quality. American Society of Heating, Refrigerating and Air-Conditioning Engineers.
- ASHRAE (2022b). Position Document on Indoor Carbon Dioxide. American Society of Heating, Refrigerating and Air-Conditioning Engineers.
- Bureau of Meteorology. Daily Weather Observations, Moorabbin Airport (station 086077). http://www.bom.gov.au/climate/dwo/
- Emmerich, S. J. & Persily, A. K. (2001). State-of-the-Art Review of CO_2 Demand Controlled Ventilation Technology and Application. NISTIR 6729, National Institute of Standards and Technology.
- Hampel, F. R. (1974). The influence curve and its role in robust estimation. *Journal of the American Statistical Association*, 69(346), 383–393.
- Künsch, H. R. (1989). The jackknife and the bootstrap for general stationary observations. *Annals of Statistics*, 17(3), 1217–1241.
- Pedregosa, F. et al. (2011). Scikit-learn: Machine learning in Python. *Journal of Machine Learning Research*, 12, 2825–2830. Documentation for LinearRegression, DecisionTreeRegressor, SVR, MLPRegressor, GridSearchCV and TimeSeriesSplit: https://scikit-learn.org/
- Persily, A. & de Jonge, L. (2017). Carbon dioxide generation rates for building occupants. *Indoor Air*, 27(5), 868–879.
- Pérez-Lombard, L., Ortiz, J. & Pout, C. (2008). A review on buildings energy consumption information. *Energy and Buildings*, 40(3), 394–398.

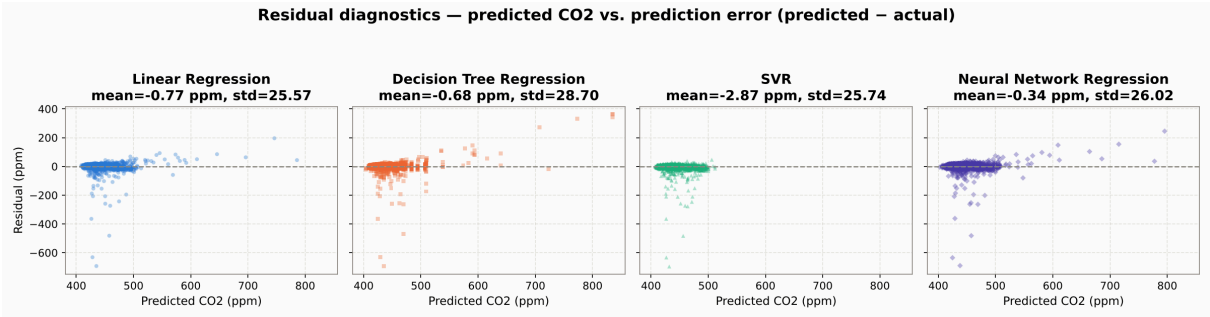
Appendix A: Supplementary Model Plots



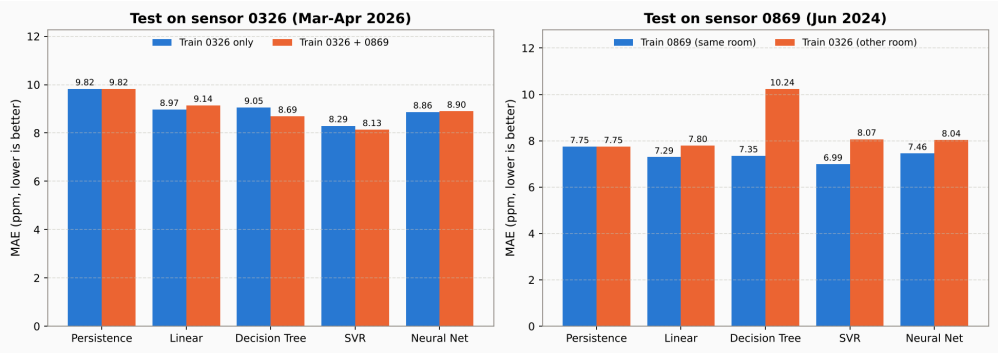
Ground truth and all four models (original settings): full test period as daily means (top) and a five-day window at 15-minute resolution (bottom). Every model follows a spike one step late; the original Decision Tree also predicts spikes that never happened.



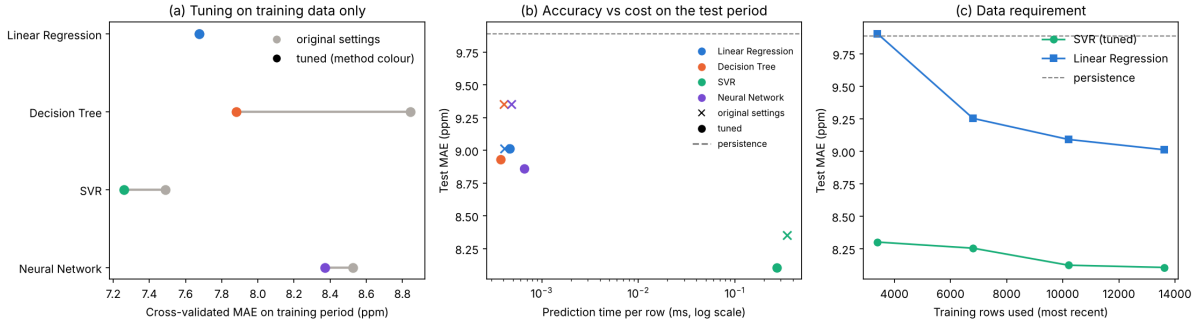
Predicted vs actual CO_2 on the test period (original settings), with $y = x$



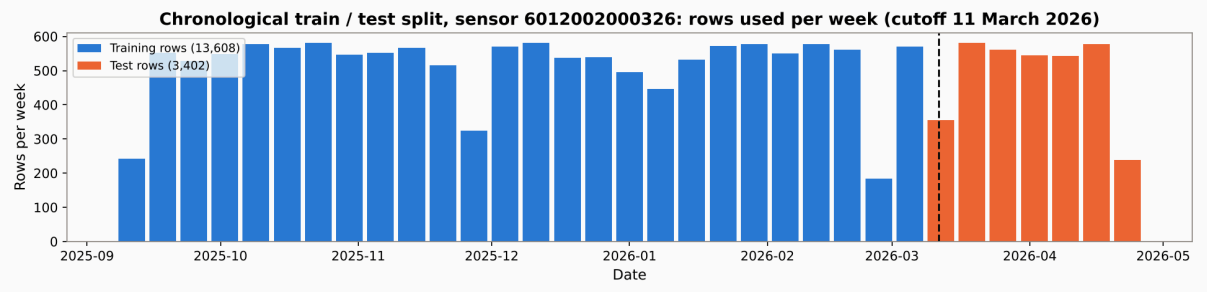
Residual (predicted minus actual) vs predicted CO_2



MAE when pooling sensors (left) and transferring between rooms (right) (Section 5.3)



Tuning on training data (a), accuracy against prediction cost (b), and data requirement (c), Sections 5.4–5.6



Rows used per week for sensor 0326, split chronologically at 11 March 2026; the record before September 2025 contains no genuine readings.

Appendix B: Numerical Integration Cross-Check

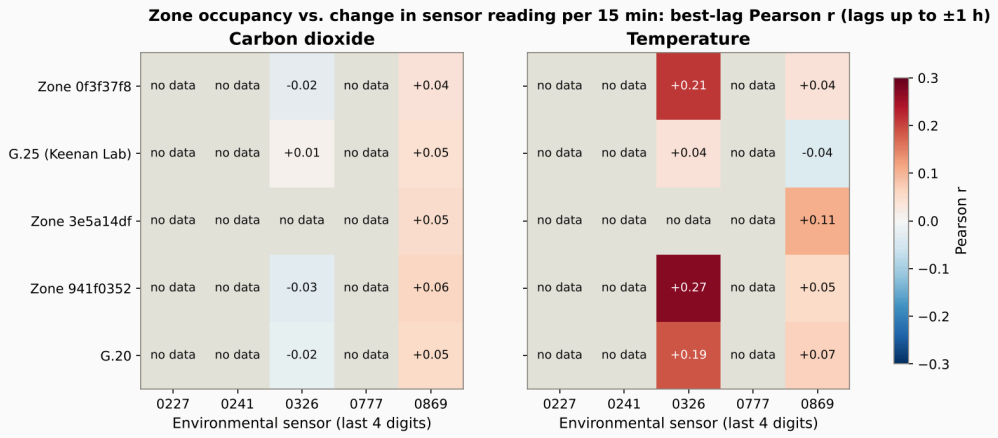
Cumulative CO_2 exposure on a 41-hour gap-free window (1–3 October 2025), sensor 0326 (`scripts/co2_integration_analysis.py`).

Bin size	Points	Trapezoidal (ppm·h)	Simpson's (ppm·h)	Relative difference
15 min	163	17,817.3	17,829.9	0.071%
30 min	83	18,019.8	18,019.9	0.001%
60 min	41	17,583.8	17,571.8	0.068%

The two rules agree within 0.1% at each spacing. The differences *between* spacings come from averaging the readings into different bins, not from integration error, so this is a consistency check; the order of accuracy is verified separately against an exact integral (Section 4.1).

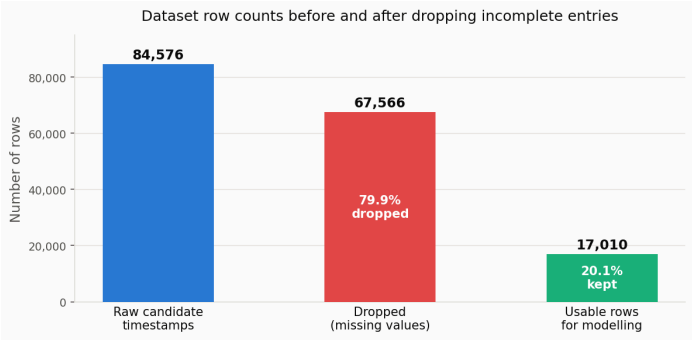
Appendix C: Sensor Audit

Sensor (last 4 digits)	Raw rows	Distinct readings	Stale re-sent rows	Usable intervals	Hours	Usable rows
0326	58,909	29,039	29,342	649	4,978	17,317
0869	29,341	13,800	15,297	458	2,403	7,781
0241	58,908	2	58,908	0	0	0
0227	21,363	1	21,363	0	0	0
0777	10,926	1	10,926	0	0	0



Best-lag correlation between each zone's occupancy and the 15-minute change in each sensor's reading; no zone exceeds |r| = 0.03 for CO_2

Appendix D: Data Pipeline



Data pipeline: candidate timestamps, dropped rows and rows retained for modelling (Section 2.4)